Understanding Five Chapter Story Structure

The following is a lesson with examples on how to create a 5-chapter story, often referred to as a “Universal Sales Pitch,” to promote a product or service that can be applied to communications of any length in any medium. The flow is designed to respond to a target audiences questions or resistance *in an order that fits buyer psychology.*

Chapter One: you need this category — i.e., you need to take action, which will mean adopting some product or service in the category of the value we offer because not doing so will hurt your business or organization.
Chapter Two: you need our version of this category — i.e., our particular approach to this category delivers the most value in terms of features, benefits, deployment, and direct fit with your needs and priorities.
Chapter Three: we’ll hold your hand every step of the way — i.e., not only will the product or service serve your needs better than other options, we will make sure you get the benefits you are hoping for by ensuring the configuration fits, the deployment is successful, and the ongoing service keeps you happy and operational.
Chapter Four: you are not alone — i.e., other people and organizations like yours already use this offering and get large and specific value from it, so you don’t need to fear you are the bleeding edge of a new technology.
Chapter Five: let's get started — i.e., here’s how to take the first one to three specific and concrete steps to decide whether to purchase and deploy.

Chapter 2, Chapter 3, and often Chapter 4 are derived from the 3-Tier Message resulting from completion the Persuasion Foundation Formula. Chapter 1 is a context-setting introduction to compel action that should respond to the priorities and needs of the target persona. In a sense, you can think of Chapter 1 as the pain the particular target persona will feel resulting from the absence of the benefits of Chapter 2 differentiation, ideally expressed in a quantifiable way that makes the target persona profoundly uncomfortable with the status quo. Chapter 5 is a situation-specific desired call to action likely to change for each campaign or communication. If no 3-Tier message exists, Chapter 2, 3, and 4 can be derived from details on the target persona; persona priorities and needs; company, product, or service differentiation; and clarity of how that differentiation responds directly to the persona’s top priorities and needs. In the absence of a 3-Tier message for reference, this content must be provided by the user via questions to the user and remembered for future use by additional users from the same organization.

We will look at each Chapter in detail to know how to create it.

Chapter One, “You need this category,” begs a simple starting question: What is a category? Well, we want to think about in this as an education section is to say, you need the kind of thing I offer. You need to understand that no adopting some offering from some company will hurt you and your organization. In this chapter the tone is specific that you do not need my offering. We'll talk about my particular offering in a later chapter. But what. You do need is to take action and adopt something in this category. But how big and how specific is a category? For example, let’s imagine you are an investment advisor. One of the first things you might be tempted to think is a category is “you need money.” While that’s related to your service, it too big and broad. What is your category? What is the thing you are a part of that people don't realize they need to have as part of their life? So what you might say is, “A lot of people manage their own money, make their own decisions, do their own investing. But what I'm telling you is you can do better with outside help, you can do better with a specialist, you can do better with someone that's focused only on you, you can do better with someone that has done this for their whole life and does nothing else.” The category is financial analysts. I'm not talking about me or my specific service yet. I'm telling you, you should think about getting help. And if you don’t get help, you will waste time and get worse investing results. Let's try a different example. Let's say I'm Tesla, so I want to sell you a beautiful Tesla electric car. My Chapter One is not to tell you about Tesla, my chapter one is “Electric cars should be part of your life. They help the environment, they are super fun to drive. They are gorgeous, they are quiet.” This is the category we want to sell you on. We want you to be uncomfortable taking no action and continuing to drive your non-electric car, so you feel pressure to take action. We haven’t talked about the value of Tesla among electric cars yet. Chapter one is exclusively the focus on taking action and adopting a product or service in this category — electric cars in the example. The measure of when you are ready to move to chapter 2 is when your listener or reader realizes they should take action. They should not continue their status quo. When they realize they should make a change, you’re ready for Chapter two.

Chapter two, “You need our version of the category,” is the chapter that most people love to work on and feel most comfortable creation. That’s because the theme is “Let me tell you all about me.” All about my unique value, my differentiation, my specific approach and strategy in the category that is a superior fit with you needs. So at this point, going back to the financial analysis example, we might switch to content like “Not all people in this field are equal financial analysts. Not all of them only have a fiduciary responsibly to prioritize only your needs. For example, some of them make money when they make trades. You don't want those kinds of people. You want people like me who

are legally required to only work on your behalf." Or you might say, "Some people offer many different financial services. I only do one thing, and that is focus on the success of your financial portfolio, so I have more time and experience to focus on your priority of maximizing your investing results." This is the what we mean by "You need my version of this category." Switching back to the Tesla example, this becomes, "You want an electric car that's got autonomous driving that cheaper electric cars don't have." Or "You want our fit and finish and design." Or "You want our guarantees or our supercharger network so you can go all over the country and get free fuel." The order and emphasis on which chapter two differentiation you use is based specifically on responding to the highest needs identified about the persona in the Three-Tier message or other inputs. So chapter two is when you're talking about you and your differentiation. You have moved to telling the customer, "Not only do you need this category, you need my version of this category." That's Chapter Two, "You need our version of the category." The measure of when you are ready to move to chapter three is when your listener or reader realizes you probably have a superior offering, but they still fear that their unique needs may not be met. They fear that while the approach you offer may be better, they will not themselves realize the promised value to their priorities will not be met. When they realize you may have a superior approach even if they have deployment and project success fears, you're ready for Chapter three.

Chapter Three, "we will hold your hand every step of the way," is where we help people feel comfortable making the decision to adopt your product or service. It can be scary to adopt a new category. In our example, they've never had any financial planner, and now you want them to use your services. Or they've never had any electric vehicle, and now you want them to buy an expensive Tesla? What are the things you're going to do to make sure they actually realize all the benefits of the category you've described in Chapter 1? The details of this chapter must be specific to your offering and different for every company, but examples of the kinds of things included might be: you make the transaction process easy, you make sure their questions are answered, deployment will be smooth and on schedule, service will be fast and reasonably priced, you will monitor their usage to make sure they are using all the features and benefits that map to their priorities, you will advocate for their needs with future revisions of your product or service. You talk about all the things you will do to "hold your hand" and make sure you're happy with your purchase and getting the value you need to respond to your priorities. The measure of when you are ready to move to chapter four is when your listener or reader realizes adopting something in the category will improve their life by responding to their priorities and needs, and they realize your offering is different from and better than other offerings, and they believe you will take care of them and ensure they realize the promised benefits from purchase through adoption through support. When they realize they should make a change, you are superior, and you will support them, you're ready for Chapter four.

Chapter four, "You're not alone," is where we explain that people and organizations just like the potential customer are already using your offering and getting the promised value. In our financial analyst example, you might say, "Let me tell you about longtime customers of my financial analyst business and their results." The the more-similar the customer examples are to the prospect to whom you're speaking, the better. So you might say, Current customers include business executives from Acme corporation and General Motors." Or for an individual purchases, you might say, "I have longtime customers or clients just starting in their career and trying to figure out what their lifelong financial plan should be." That is, a tailored form of "People like you use my service and are incredibly happy with results that match their priorities. Let me show you their testimonials." In our Tesla example, you might say "Tesla is the number one selling luxury car, whether electric or non-electric, in the entire state of California and is the fastest growing car in China." One critical nuance of chapter 4 is you must think about the desired call to action and not simply talk about other using your overall offering. For example, if your desired call to action is for an existing customer to upgrade to the latest version of your offering, you would not simply go back to talking about people or organizations using your product as you would for a potential brand new customer; instead, you talk about people or organizations who have completed the upgrade and the benefits they are seeing from taking that action. That's the core of chapter four: "You're not alone." The measure of when you are ready to move to chapter five is when your listener or reader realizes adopting something in the category will improve their life, and they realize your offering is different from and better than other offerings, and they believe you will take care of them and ensure they realize the promised benefits from purchase through adoption through support. But they still have taken no actions to build momentum toward adoption. When they realize they should make a change, you are superior, and you will support them, you're ready for Chapter five.

And finally, **Chapter five, "Let's get started,"** is where we ask the person to take the first one to three concrete steps to build momentum toward adoption, i.e., the call to action. The premise is once people take an initial action or two, they are far more likely to take additional steps ultimately leading to adoption. You might say things like, "Let's sit down together right now and fill out this tailored form to help my team configure the best solution" or "We can start next week by doing an audit of your operations to recommend an ideal configuration" or "If you introduce me to the person on your team who will run the project, I'll make sure that person is successful and we won't have to take up

more of your time." In our Financial Adviser example, we might say, "We should start by analyzing your portfolio to look for opportunities and exposure." For our Tesla example, we might say, "I recommend a test drive of these two models to narrow down your preference." We want the "Let's get started" chapter to be very simple, short, inexpensive, and non-intimidating. Therefore, we typically have only the first two or three steps in the process. Some additional examples of the desired simplicity, concreteness, and clarity of value delivered by chapter five tied to our ongoing examples include, "We're going to do an audit of your financial needs. We'll recommend a full solution by Friday. Then, a month from now, you will have a new financial plan that will give you confidence for the next 3 years" or "After a test drive and some paperwork I'll manage for you, you'll have a gorgeous Tesla in your garage and never need to visit another gas station." We want to make that Call to Action extremely simple and concrete. That's Chapter Five, let's get started.

Real-World Example

To review, that's chapter one, you need this category. Chapter two, you need our version of the category. Chapter three, we're going to hold your hand every step of the way. Chapter four, you are not alone. And chapter five, let's get started. Let's apply this in depth to a real example working with CEO of a company with a fairly strange and unfamiliar offering, so it becomes a good test of the universality of the approach.

Let's start by describing this unusual business. You are aware of the concept of life insurance, right? With life insurance, you pay a premium every month or every six months and then if you die, an insurance company gives money to your family or other beneficiary, that's classic life insurance. Well, it turns out, there's a little-known pocket in the life insurance market where people get life insurance when there are younger and pay their premiums year after year. Maybe their kids are young, so they want to take care of their kids if something happens to them. And years pass. Decades pass. Now the person is in their 60s or 70s, or 80s, maybe quite ill, and they need money, perhaps for health care. And their kids may be older and working and no longer subject to dramatic financial ruin if they die. And at that same time their premiums on their existing life insurance is getting more expensive every year; they might be paying $20,000 a year, just in premiums, and they're saying this is too much money for benefits that aren't as important anymore, so they decide "I'm just going to turn this off, I'm going to call the insurance, I'll stop paying for these premiums." And so what happens? The insurance companies happy about this because they've been getting premiums for 30 or 40 years or more, and instantly, they never have to pay out on the policy. With that backdrop, a new industry arose. And it can seem kind of creepy. It works like this: a new company comes to you and says, "You are 79 years old, you have a serious medical condition that is very expensive data to manage, and because you're retired, you don't have a lot of income coming in. But you've got a million dollar life insurance policy. How about if I give you $700,000, for that million dollar life insurance policy and I will continue to pay the premiums until you die and then I get the insurance payout." For an older person managing health challenges who needs money, $700,000 is a lot of money, right? It represents 70% the ultimate policy payout. And that person can stop paying those growing premiums, so their savings or income can go further toward other needs like healthcare or travel or other expenses. Some might find it creepy to know a company only makes a profit on the transaction when you die. But this is a real business that has benefits to both the seller of the policy and the buyer of the policy. The person selling the policy gets money before they die. And the company buying the policy pays the premiums and eventually gets paid because we all die at some point. So from the company's perspective, their models to, first, raise money from investors; second, use that money to buy policies and to pay future premiums as described above; and third, wait until the person dies to collect the full value of the policy. That's the way the business works. The CEO in our example founded a company like this. The CEO's challenge was not to get older policy holders to sell him their policy. Instead, the CEO's challenge was to convince investors to invest in this unusual business. So let's talk about the five chapter story this CEO and his company used to convince investors that a good use of a portion of their portfolio should be to purchase and maintain payments on life insurance policies from these older, often-ill insurance policy holders.

To begin with the end in mind, we're remember our five chapters: you need this category, you need our version of this category, we're going to hold your hand every step of the way, you are not alone, and let's get started.

Start with Chapter One, you need this category. But why do you need this category? Let's remember the CEO's target audience — his prospect — was not to the people with the policies. His five chapter story was to investors — his pitch was to the people who want to invest in the company to buy these policies. What's the category? It appears to be investment options, so let's dig into the details of this business relative to other investment options.

First of all, the investments really help the policy holder. The company is providing what might be a last chance option for the policy holder to have financial security for the last part of their life. The last opportunity for these people to

have a comfortable end of their life comes directly from from this business. Okay, that's nice. But investors don't make investment decisions purely for altruism. But there is much more to why this category is attractive. There is more to why "You need this category." When an economy gets bad, almost every investment alternative to this category goes down, right? When the economy is bad stock market goes down. When the economy is bad, your bond value often goes down. When the economy is bad, the value of your real estate goes down. So when the economy is down, it can seem like every investment option loses value. However, life insurance has nothing to do with the economy, right? People live. People die. We're all human. It's a natural process. It has nothing to do with the economy. So suddenly, investing in the purchase of life insurance policies becomes an investment that has nothing to do with the economy. The economy goes down, but this investment value stays the same. That is very unusual in the investment world. Most investments move together, so they are called correlated. But this investment does not move with the others, so in the industry, they say it is "counter cyclical." This is a super big deal. This alone makes an investment category very attractive. What else? Perhaps the most important measure of an investment category is likely total return — how much money can you make on your investments. So what are the alternatives? If I put my money in a bank checking account, I may make less than 1%. If I put it in the bond market, I make maybe 4% or 5%. If I put money in the stock market in a good year or at least over a long period of time, maybe I make 7% or 8%. If I put money in real estate, who knows? It turns out an investment in this life insurance market can deliver over 12% annually. That's a high return, especially for a low-risk, counter-cyclical investment. So chapter 1 starts to take form. Why do you need this category? Because it isn't affected by the economy and the returns are really high. For an investor, that may be all they need to know to realize they could be better off if part of their portfolio. So the investor's reaction might be exactly what we want from Chapter one: "Hmm. I've never thought this category of investing. Okay, I'm listening." That's all we want to hear to move to chapter two. You need our version.

So Chapter two, you need our version of the category? Why? Well, first of all, a whole bunch of companies in this business are really slimy and exploitative. They find ill, older policy holders who are desperate. They try to give them five cents on the dollar. They exploit them. They abuse their desperation. We don't do that. Here's the records. We treat people well. All right, that's good, but just a start. Second, many of these companies are unprofessional fly-by-night operations. They take your investment money, buy the policies, pay the premiums and maybe if the person passes away and the policy pays off, maybe you get your money. But it's hard to tell if you're getting a fair deal. That's not the kind of company you, as an investor, want to trust with you money. As the CEO told me, our version is a commitment to strong security, great record keeping, and professional corporate culture. He says, "we run this like a top notch business." So they don't exploit people. They're more professional. The investor may think, "I like their approach better than others in the field. And that's the only goal of chapter two, right? Chapter One response: "I like the category because it's counter cyclical, offers high returns, and even helps people. And chapter two investor response: "I like these people. They don't they don't exploit policy holders and they run their business like professionals. But it seems like a hassle to get started since it's new for me." So we're ready for chapter three.

What's chapter three? We'll hold your hand every step of the way, right? The CEO needs to communicate his understanding this is a new and complicated business. And to some, it's kind of creepy. His potential investor is likely to have a lot of questions. So how does the CEO and his company "hold their hand every step of the way?" The CEO says it starts with being open to questions. He gives his mobile number to every one of his investors and says, "You call me anytime you've got a question. And we're going to make the process easy. For example, we need some legal paperwork that requires that a third party to confirm you are who you say you are. That third party is called a notary in the United States. So the CEO can say, "Instead of you having to drive across town, we'll send a Notory to your office. We know you're busy, so we'll make it so easy." The core message of chapter three is all the ways "We'll hold your hand every step of the way." The investor is starting to think, "Okay, I like the idea of this kind of investment. I like how you'll make it easy, but I just don't want to be on the bleeding edge. This sounds kind of scary because I've never done it."

That leads us to chapter four: You're not alone. The CEO explains, "One of the most famous investors in the United States is Warren Buffett, who runs a company called Berkshire Hathaway. He started investing in life insurance policies 15 years ago. And lets talk about my own clients. I will give you a list, with client profiles and their goals. For example, one client is a vice-president in a major company, who wanted better-performing investments. Or another client with a family business managing money for their entire family and looking for investments that felt safer than the stock market with high returns. Or here's a client who is new to investing and wanting to start a broad, well-diversified portfolio." By walking the potential investor through the clients most like them, the CEO can assure the investor they can feel comfortable investing because "they are not alone."

And then finally, he moves to chapter five, "Let's get started." In this case, he now says, "There are three steps you need to be authorized. It's an unusual investment. So we need to go through a process to make sure that you are

designated by the government as ‘an informed investor.’ We can walk you through this process tomorrow. Then you will decide how much you want to invest. And then we'll work with you to transfer the money to us to purchase the policies and pay the premiums. After these three easy steps, you can be fully invested by the end of a month. Is there anything standing in the way of taking first step?”

Summarizing this real-world example from an unusual company, the five chapter story which can be applied to live discussion, and email, or even a web page description looks something like the following. The following example is short with approximately one sentence per chapter. But the outline would be the same for a two-hour discussion, a 45-minute presentation to a group of investors, or one-page business letter.

1. Investing in life insurance policies is critical to a well-diversified, recession-proof portfolio because the returns are higher than typical investments can return and not correlated with the rest of the economy. And the policy puchases deliver enomous human value to the policy sellers.
2. Our professionalism and clear reporting to you, as well as our treatment of the policy sellers makes us a safer and more honorable way to invest in this category.
3. We pride ourselves on making the decision and investing process easy and clear.
4. Investors like you, whether large investors with billion-dollar portfolios or individuals in the middle of their career invest with us and have realized returns of 14% over the last two years, even higher than our 12% target.
5. Just say the word, and I’ll send someone over to walk you through the logistics and paperwork so you can be part of this investment opportunity by the end of the month.

We’ve now completed a detailed example of this unusual, somewhat creepy business. We’ve shown the approach applies to a major company like Tesla, a mainstream service like financial advising, and even this unusual life insurance investment company. And as long as you and your company are truly adding value, and you are differentiated within your category (sometimes called a segment), the five chapter story structure will work for you.

How do you get started in applying this to daily work?

First, for chapter one, figure out your category. What is the space your business is in that you can describe as having value that matches the priorities and needs of your customer? That's chapter one, you need this category.
Then, for Chapter Two, what are all the things that differentiate you from other in the category— the things that make you special. The easiest and most effective way to organize this differentiation is using the 3-Tier message structure resulting from Persuasion Foundation Formula. That formula is the ideal input to the 5 chapter story because it is all about figuring out the needs of your customers, your prospects, and mapping your value to the priorities and needs of your target buyer. That's how you are different and better. That is your chapter two: you need our version of this category.
Then move to your chapter three, what are all the ways you can make life easier for customers and ensure they get the promised value? Everybody's busy. How do you hold their hand, take away their fear, make sure they're clear on every aspect of your business, make them comfortable doing business with you? That's chapter three, we'll hold your hand.
Then work on Chapter Four, you're not alone. Who are your customers today? And whenever possible, who are your current customers who are most like this prospect? As a detail for chapter four, if you don't have customers, don't give up. If you have a new business, you can talk about typical customers of business like yours to show it’s a mainstream offering. But as you’d expect, as quickly as you can, start to gather the people that are truly your customers and get testimonials with documented results.
And then finally, refine you’re Chapter five. What are the first one to three steps to get started? Make them simple, inexpensive, and concrete. You don’t want to end with something like “Okay, you go away and think for two weeks. And I’ll follow up then.” That's not an action. That doesn’t build momentum. An action is “We're going to sit down tomorrow and document your needs. Then I'm going to call Monday with a tailored configuration of my product or my service. And with your agreement, you will be up and running in 10 days.” Notice how concrete this is.

So at this point, I'm hoping we can say this together.
Chapter One, you need this category.
Chapter two, you need our version of this category.
Chapter three, we will hold your hand every step of the way.
Chapter Four, you are not alone.
Chapter Five, let's get started.

Multiple Ways to Think about the Five Chapter Story

Sometimes a model gets clearer through different lenses. You don't need to care about the perspective of every row below, but if it's not clear how or why one applies, it's worth asking because the discussion is likely to save you time delivering something that drives revenue.

	Chapter 1	Chapter 2	Chapter 3	Chapter 4	Chapter 5
Category	You need *this category*	You need *our version* of this category	We'll hold your hand every step of the way	You're not alone	Let's get started
Goal	Compel action	Give advice	Give assurance	Give proof	Give direction
Outcome	Make the status quo unattractive (why change? Why now?)	Make the choice obvious	Eliminate risk	Give confidence	Clarify *first* actions
What audience thinks *before* moving to next	"Damn. I didn't really need something new on my top three list but you're totally right and I need to do something. I don't need whatever YOU are selling. But I need to do something."	"All right, you make a good case your approach to this important problem might be the right approach. The solution sounds good. But I don't have time for anything new right now and I am just not convinced it'll work for us."	"At least we both have skin of the game to make sure this thing is successful. I like the way you work with customers and it sounds like you won't drop me after I pay, but really try to make things work. But I'm still not ready to be on the bleeding edge or so anything until I'm confident this will work."	"I guess if your stuff work that well and folks are that happy at places so much like ours, it'll probably work for us. I'm still crazy business and I don't know if it's worth my time, but I'm intrigued."	"Ok, that seems like a risk-free, easy first step. And at least I'm doing … something! So ok, let's just do the first step or two and see what happens."
Sales Technique	Challenger Selling	Feature/Benefit selling (Classic)	Solution Selling	Reference Selling	Always be closing!

Advanced Considerations: Taking the Next Step

Deeper Dive into Chapter One — Foundation of Everything

Chapter 1 starts everything and compels the listener to act. We know the easiest 5-chapter story (5cs) is derived from the 3-tier message covered in the Persuasion Foundation Formula. And you know my glib rule of thumb: "communication is math," i.e., you start at the beginning and if you follow the logic without finding a fallacy, you have to say yes. (And if you don't say yes, you're forced into an uncomfortable cognitive dissonance where your brain led you to a decision you're not following!)

So the 5cs becomes a reasoning and logic game *that Chapter One must set up a profound compelling reason to take action which is instantly responded to in Chapter 2.* So you write your most-effective Chapter One after you know what Chapter Two will promise.

What's the relationship of Chapter 1 to Tier 1?

We'll dig into Chapter One thinking using Filemaker 2024 as our model. The current Tier 1 from Andrew (already embedded in iSolution's AI agent) is "With FileMaker 2024, you can quickly add new AI capabilities to your apps to get more value from your existing data - safely and responsibly." So Chapter Two will include this message, plus the Tier 2 value statements.

So let's look closer: Tier 1 (which informs Chapter 2) clearly targets a Paula who's ALREADY a Claris user, which makes sense since we know current Claris strategy is installed base health and expansion. If she weren't already a user, then the phrase "existing data" wouldn't make sense.

Therefore, while a 5cs may change for each tactic, a compelling Chapter One leading to *that* Chapter Two would include something that sets the table for the AI promise, at a length appropriate for the medium. And example would be, "If you're running Filemaker apps in your org, you're probably getting questions — and maybe pressure — to find ways to use AI to save time and boost productivity. Every org we know is trying to figure this out, since ignoring AI and what it can offer puts even the most successful organizations at risk. But until now, your AI work and your Claris and Filemaker work have probably been separate. While most tech companies are telling you to rethink your dev

efforts completely with new AI initiatives, our goal is to let you extend what you have with AI tools making your current apps better."

What's critical to notice is the Chapter One opening is not a general statement about Filemaker 2024 value. It's designed to directly set up the Tier One value statement from the 3-Tier. And as usual, that Chapter One, when finished makes the audience uncomfortable with their status quo and compels action with fear or opportunity.

What's the relationship of Chapter 1 to Persona?

The *first* question I ask when asked to review sales or marketing material is: "Who is the audience?" A Five Chapter story is the same. So how do we make it easier and faster to target your Chapter 1 to your audience persona? *The value promise of the Chapter 1 — "You need this category" — must come from the persona's highest priorities*. It's that simple.

Let's make the task easier. For each persona, your options for what you highlight in Chapter 1 are limited to *persona priorities*, even if you ultimately offer the same solution to each. For example, imagine you are selling a development platform capable of delivering custom apps with a gorgeous UX on any client platform. And let's imagine three persona are critical to a purchase decision: the CEO, who authorizes the expense and cares about business growth and profitability; the CIO, who approves the platform and cares most about uptime and security; and the Developer, who authors the custom apps and cares about efficiency and capability. While the Chapter 1 "You need this category" promise must be *true* for all of them, the focus matches their priority. For the CEO, "Your business will only reach its potential with technology support tailored to your unique business requirements." For the CIO, "Even the most-tailored custom apps hurt your business if employees can't depend on availability or if their use puts the company at a compliance or security risk." For the Developer, "A development platform is only useful if it supports your ability to deliver effective solutions to both today's challenges and future requirements." Continuing the example, *even if you believe the most powerful and differentiated value you offer is a beautiful mobile UX*, if this is not the top priority of these three persona, it is not the focus of your Chapter 1. It may help to think of the persona's priorities as a "lens" on what value to emphasize — a "lens" that only shows the persona's priorities. Selecting what value to emphasize from this narrowed list of options makes it easier and faster to deliver your draft.

Does Chapter Order Ever Change … *or Does That Break the Model?*

If you use the Five Chapter story format in daily work, you'll soon become quick at delivering effective first drafts. And soon after, you may start to question whether certain situations encourage a different chapter order. Why? After all, didn't I claim the chapter order is designed to *provide the info at the moment your audience is ready to hear it?* For example, almost no one will care about your free trial (a Chapter 5 topic) if they don't care about the problems you solve (a Chapter 1 topic). But audiences and situations vary. So not surprisingly, *the answer to whether order can change is "Yes … sometimes. That's why the Five Chapter story is only your first draft."* In my experience, Chapter 4 – "You're not alone" – is most likely to move around. For example, there may be times a less-known company's biggest obstacle is just being taken seriously enough engage in conversation. They may find the their target audience will only engage if they know smart, well-known companies use their offering. They may find the greatest success by starting with a Chapter Four topic something like, "Five of the seven largest financial companies in the world use us. Are you a little curious why?" Beyond that example, the takeaway is delivering a first draft quickly gives you time to think about what's unique about your situation … for *this* audience … on *this* day … trying to compel *this* action.

Are Chapters Always the Same Length? *No Way. The "Slinky" Model.*

One promise of the Five Chapter Story is "any length." The shortest Five Chapter Story is usually five sentences. The longest might be an hour presentation or even a full day workshop where audiences explore the claims in each chapter, perhaps looking at alternatives, to convince themselves they should follow through with your Chapter Five actions. So in your early work, each chapter may be about the same length — a sentence, a presentation module, a workshop session, etc.

But as you'd expect, this isn't always appropriate or effective. Early in a sales cycle, your focus is more likely on the need for action — a Chapter One topic. Other times, you're trying to build confidence with reference stories — a Chapter Four topic.

The visual for me seeing the 5 chapters as sort of a spring, like a toy Slinky. Think of your spring or Slinky toy having five rubber balls distributed along the length with a segment of spring between each one. The rubber balls are the

start of your chapters and the segment of the Slinky is the length of that chapter. Not only can you squish the Slinky to make it short, you can stretch the Slinky to make it long. This fits the promise of “any length.” But more than that, you can squish some of the segments and stretch others. The idea is that using all 5 chapters in most applications (i.e., other than, say, a Tweet/X post) is the *easiest, fastest path to a persuasive 1st draft.* That is, it still matches info to the “order” of your audience’s resistance points. But a Five Chapter Story practitioner becomes expert at shrinking and expanding chapters to fit a given audience at a specific moment in their buying cycle.

For example, a new audience may need a detailed, compelling Chapter One just to be willing to give you a few minutes to listen to your story. In that case, you might only include a tiny Chapter Four because reference details matter less than “name dropping.” On the other hand, true believers you’re asking to take a new step like upgrading to a new version might need a tiny Chapter One just to reconfirm we’re still speaking their language and focused on their problems, but a long Chapter Four 4 to see the depth of commitment, ROI, and testimonial details of others. While Chapter Five depth can also vary based on whether the desired action is “keep doing what you’re doing” versus “how to upgrade without breaking your existing deployment,” my general encouragement is to keep Chapter Five relatively short, easy, and inexpensive to make it easier to say “yes.”

To me, this visual mental model builds on what’s most useful about the Five Chapter Story — a format to deliver rapid first drafts that respond to the thinking process and resistance points of a target audience — *while keeping the flexibility to respond to changing audience requirements*.